

At first, Franklin was able to pay child support while he worked full-time. He only stopped paying after he began to attend school in order to become a chiropractor. Franklin felt some guilt over not paying, but he convinced himself that it was unfair to expect a poor student to be responsible for child support. He was finishing up his chiropractic training and could barely survive on student loans.

After he graduated, he discovered that he was prohibited from getting a chiropractor's license because of his outstanding child support payments. Again, Franklin complained. How was he supposed to make a living without a professional license? His only choice was to become a masseuse.

Unfortunately, he earned much less as a masseuse than he would have made as a chiropractor. In addition, Franklin had high monthly payments for his student loans. Franklin did not feel responsible for paying his student loans back because he never became a chiropractor. Since his education had not led to a job, his loans had been for nothing. Therefore, why should he pay them?

He decided to file for bankruptcy. He chose to save money through a "do-it-yourself" bankruptcy. Franklin went down to the court and picked up the bankruptcy forms that he filled in himself without legal counsel. He found it a liberating experience. No longer would he have the burden of these massive loans. This peace of mind lasted only until he discovered that student loans were not dischargeable in a bankruptcy. In fact, neither were his child support obligations.

Nonpayment of these non-dischargeable debts can lead to extreme measures of collection, including garnishing of wages, levying (seizing) funds in a bank account, seizing income tax refunds, and the inability to obtain or maintain certain professional licenses (in some states this includes drivers' licenses).

These measures may appear severe, but 2003 data from the

